Why Do Young Americans Support More Redistribution?

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Abstract

Young Americans support redistribution far more strongly than older Americans, and this age gap has widened substantially over recent decades. Using a purpose-built survey of roughly 2,000 adults, balanced equally between those younger and older than 30, we test a broad range of explanations for the gap—economic self-interest, life-cycle and consumption-smoothing motives, exposure to long-run risks, and differences in beliefs, values, and time preferences. A robustness analysis isolates only two systematically robust and quantitatively large determinants: zero-sum beliefs and the belief that progressive taxation blunts incentives. Income and financial position, exposure to risk, and social-mobility beliefs play little role, and demographics account for only a modest share. Differences in zero-sum thinking alone explain the majority of the young–old gap. We replicate these patterns in independent cross-sectional and longitudinal surveys—the GSS, the ANES, and Chinoy et al. (2026)—and show that the age gradient has steepened markedly since the 1970s, with the widening in zero-sum beliefs accounting for a sizable share of the trend. We conclude by examining what may have driven the change in the age distribution of zero-sum beliefs.

Keywords:

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New Outline 1. Understand the generational gaps in preferences for redistribution based on several hypotheses (our survey) — the unique nature of our survey 2. Confirm the main finding with other surveys (Stantcheva) 3. Document the widening gap (discuss generation vs. period effects) 4. Explain the widening gap (income inequality, mobility, immigration) — this might be the part that still needs a bit of work

1 Introduction

In the United States, at any given point in time, young people are much more supportive of government intervention to reduce inequality than older people are. Figure 1 presents this pattern in four recent surveys: (i) our own 2025 survey of roughly 2,000 adults split equally between those younger and older than 30, (ii) the survey of Chinoy et al. (2026), (iii) the most recent wave of the General Social Survey (GSS, 2021), and (iv) the most recent wave of the American National Election Study (ANES, 2024). All four reveal a strongly significant cross-sectional *age gradient*—equivalently, a *generational gap*—in the intensity of support for redistribution. Earlier surveys display the same gradient, though its steepness has evolved over time and is most pronounced in recent years.

This paper is the first to focus specifically on documenting and understanding this age gradient, using a survey designed expressly to test competing explanations for why young people hold more pro-redistributive attitudes.

One straightforward hypothesis is that young people are on average poorer than older people and would therefore gain more from redistribution (the *income* hypothesis). A related version holds that they view redistribution as a way to smooth income over the life cycle (the *life-cycle* hypothesis). A third is that young people face larger risks going forward—for example, climate and AI risk—and so place greater value on the safety net that redistribution provides (the *long-run-risk* hypothesis). A fourth is that, uncertain of their eventual position in the income distribution, they wish to hedge against the worst outcomes from behind a veil of ignorance (the *Rawlsian* hypothesis).

A second class of hypotheses concerns *beliefs* about the economic game people think they are playing. One possibility, suggested by Chinoy et al. (2026), is that young people engage in more zero-sum thinking than older people. A companion idea is that they perceive society as offering fewer opportunities for upward mobility. Another is that they hold different beliefs about the disincentive effects of redistributive taxation, or about the incentive benefits of high incomes. Finally, one can ask whether generational differences in patience, or in the inclination to give (to friends or to strangers), correlate with support for redistribution.

A robustness analysis reveals that zero-sum beliefs and the belief that redistributive taxation is disincentivizing are the only systematically robust and sizable determinants of support for redistribution. Income and financial position, and future income risk, play virtually no role, while other candidates—such as beliefs about social mobility or exposure to particular risks—matter only marginally. Moreover, the young–old difference in zero-sum beliefs explains the majority of the difference in their support for redistribution: other robust correlates, such as the perceived disincentive effect of taxation, display no age gradient of their own. Demographic variables account for only a modest share of the difference in zero-sum thinking. We confirm the main results of our survey using the information available in other surveys.

Using long-running, repeatedly fielded surveys (the GSS and ANES), we further establish that the age gradient between young and old people has widened considerably over time. Figure 2 compares the GSS and ANES across waves; the gap has roughly (doubled–tripled). Finally, we test several hypotheses about this growing age polarization in attitudes toward redistribution. We

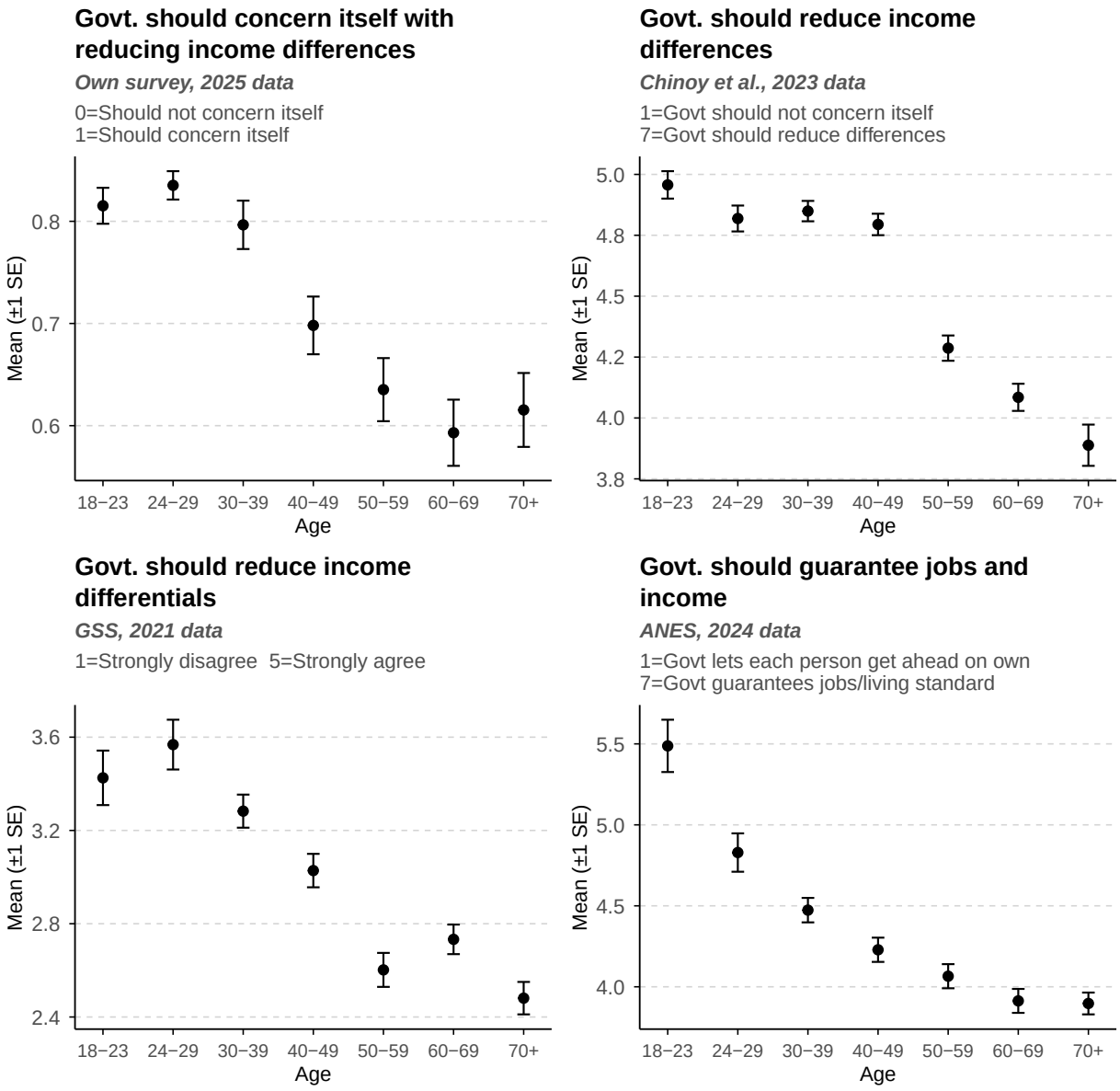


Figure 1: The age gradient in support for redistribution, across four independent datasets. Each panel plots the mean response (±1 standard error) by age bracket, using the most recent wave of each source. In every dataset, support is highest among the youngest respondents and declines steadily with age.

show that the widening gap in zero-sum thinking explains a sizable share of the change in the age gradient over time, and we examine what may have driven the underlying change in beliefs.

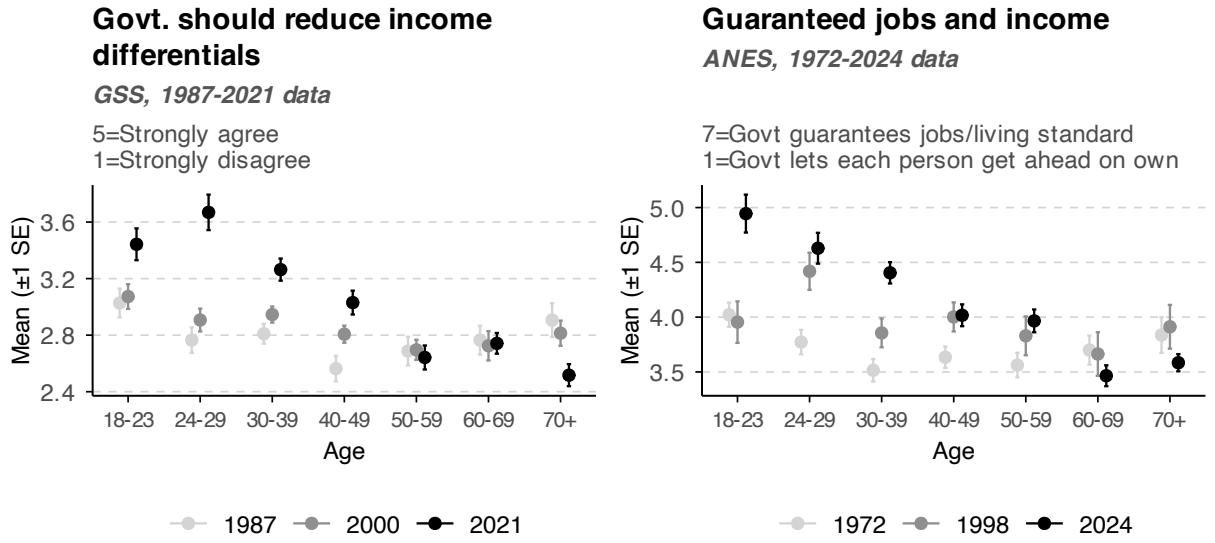


Figure 2: The age gradient has widened over time. Mean support for government reduction of income differences by age bracket (±1 standard error), for the earliest, middle, and most recent available waves of the GSS (GOVEQINC, 1987–2021) and the ANES (VCF0809, 1972–2024). The gradient is barely visible in the earliest waves and steepens markedly in the most recent ones.

This paper draws on and connects several strands of research on the determinants of redistributive preferences. A long tradition models such preferences as driven by material self-interest: in the canonical framework, individuals below the mean income favor more redistribution than those above it. Yet a large body of evidence finds that self-interest explains only a limited share of the variation in attitudes, and that beliefs, values, and perceptions of fairness matter at least as much (Alesina and Giuliano, 2011). An older political-science literature had already documented the weak explanatory power of narrow self-interest, and recent economics has increasingly turned to the beliefs people hold about how the economy works. We contribute to this shift by asking which beliefs, if any, account for a specific and growing pattern—the age gradient in redistributive support.

Whether inequality is seen as acceptable depends heavily on beliefs about its *origins*. Piketty (1995) shows how differing beliefs about the roles of effort and luck can sustain distinct long-run redistribution equilibria, and Benabou and Tirole (2006) formalize how motivated "just-world" beliefs generate a low-redistribution equilibrium alongside a high-redistribution one. Empirically, Alesina et al. (2018) document that Americans are overly optimistic about upward mobility and that those who are more pessimistic favor more redistribution, with effects that hinge on views of government. Experimental work reinforces the role of fairness views: Almås et al. (2020) find that Americans tolerate inequality arising from performance far more than inequality arising from luck, and are more efficiency-seeking than Scandinavians, while Enke (2020) links moral universalism to more redistributive political preferences.

Closest to our central finding is the recent literature on zero-sum thinking. Chinoy et al. (2026) show that a general propensity to view economic and social interactions as zero-sum strongly predicts support for redistribution, race-conscious policy, and immigration restriction, and that it

is more prevalent among younger cohorts, the descendants of enslaved people and recent immigrants, and those who have experienced less upward mobility. Davidai and Ongis (2019) document that the *domain* of zero-sum thinking is itself political: those on the left are more likely to see *economic* relations as zero-sum, while those on the right are more likely to see *social* and intergroup relations as zero-sum. We build on this work by measuring economic and social/DEI zero-sum beliefs separately and pitting them against a broad set of alternative explanations within a single survey.

A parallel literature emphasizes beliefs about the *efficiency* costs of redistribution and about government. Stantcheva (2021) shows that people reason about tax policy primarily through efficiency and fairness considerations, and that views of government mediate policy support; Kuziemko et al. (2015) find that informing people about inequality raises stated concern but shifts concrete policy support only modestly, implying preferences that are malleable yet anchored. Broader attitudes toward markets and capitalism have similar roots (Landier et al., 2008). The salience of out-groups also matters: Alesina et al. (2023) show that making immigration salient reduces support for redistribution—a channel we return to when considering what has changed over time.

Finally, a literature on formative experiences helps explain why cohorts might differ and why the gradient could be widening. Macroeconomic conditions experienced during impressionable years leave durable imprints on economic attitudes (Malmendier and Nagel, 2011), and Giuliano and Spilimbergo (2023) find that individuals who came of age during recessions place more weight on luck relative to effort and are more supportive of redistribution. This motivates our investigation of what may have shifted the beliefs of younger cohorts. Relative to these strands—each of which typically studies a single belief or a single survey—we assemble a comprehensive battery of candidate explanations in one instrument, ask which are robust and sizable, and use the answer to account for both the level and the widening of the age gradient.

The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 introduces our 2025 survey, establishes the age gradient within it, identifies the beliefs that robustly determine support for redistribution and gauges how much of the gradient they explain, and confirms these findings in other recent surveys. Section 3 documents that the gradient has widened over time and examines its evidence and determinants. Section 4 concludes.

2 Age Gradient in Support for Redistribution: Evidence from 2025 Survey

2.1 The Survey Design

Our survey was fielded in 2025 to a sample of roughly 2,000 U.S. adults recruited through Prolific, balanced equally between respondents younger and older than 30 to ensure ample statistical power on both sides of the divide of interest. Alongside a battery of redistribution-preference questions, it elicits a broad range of beliefs, values, financial circumstances, and demographics, which we exploit in later sections to adjudicate among competing explanations for the age gap. [To do: Describe the wave-1 questionnaire, the Prolific bot-screening process, and summary statistics.]
[To do: Describe wave 1 questionnaire, Prolific bot process, and summary statistics.]

2.2 Age Gradient Evidence

Our 2025 survey reveals a strong age gradient (or generational gap) in preferences for the redistribution of income and wealth.

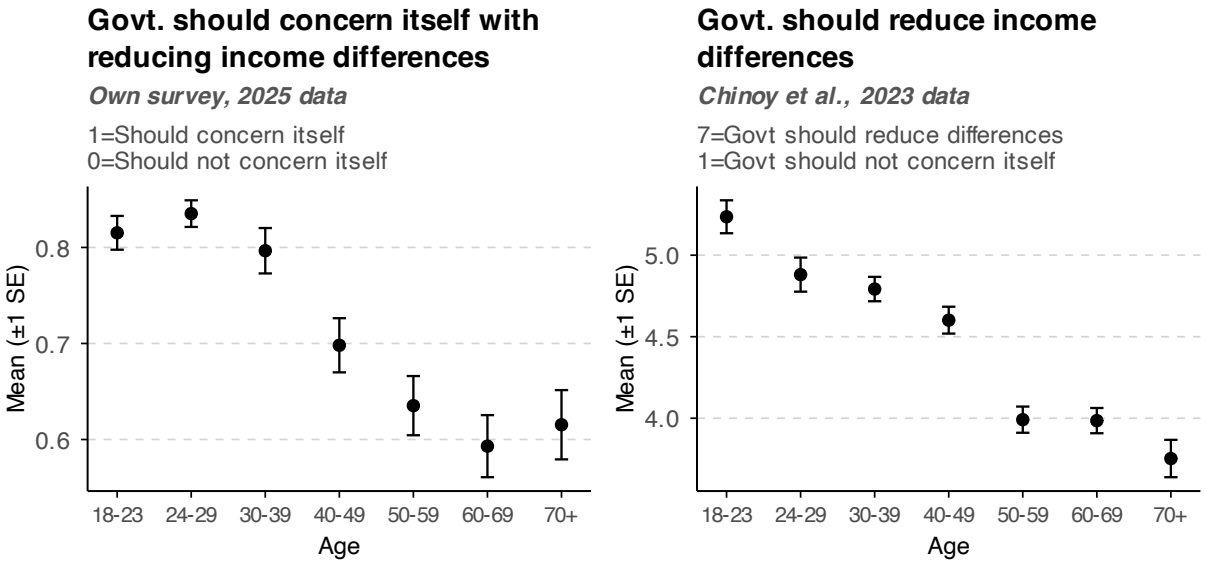


Figure 3: The cross-sectional age gradient replicates in a single wave. Mean response by age bracket (±1 standard error) in our own 2025 survey ("should the government concern itself with reducing income differences," coded 0/1) and in Chinoy et al. (2026) (1–7 scale).

[To do: Need to add labels and captions to plots, add any end-notes to , and make some latex rather than pdf]

In our online survey data, unadjusted regressions of age on policy preferences confirm the current existence of an age divide. For the binary question "Should the government concern itself with reducing income differences between rich and poor people?" we use a logistic regression, and for the remainder of the section, we use simple OLS regressions. The negative age coefficient suggests that, on average, older Americans support redistribution less and younger Americans support redistribution more.

Table 1: Single-period bivariate regressions

	shouldconcern (logit)	progressivity (OLS)	proposal (OLS)
Age	-0.4572***	-0.1096***	-0.0998***
	(0.0459)	(0.0202)	(0.0203)
N	2,415	2,415	2,415

Data: own survey, fielded 2025
Both age and outcome z-scored (per-SD units). All outcomes coded high = pro-redistribution. Standard errors in parentheses.
* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

2.3 The Robust Determinants of Support for Redistribution

[Nic: Could be a lifecycle aspect to some of these beliefs, so the title may be claiming too much.]

2.3.1 Position and financial risk: weak evidence

[To do: Insert tests/falsification.]

Three main hypotheses: (i) current income and financial strain, which is the level of financial position, (ii) perceived income/career/other financial risk (climate, housing prices, etc.), which is the variance of financial position, and (iii) expected trajectory and consumption smoothing, which is the path of financial position. Current unemployment, financial satisfaction, savings levels, and income belong to (i). The variance and lower bound of expected income and perceived exposure to climate/AI/housing risk belong to (ii). Expected growth or stagnation in income, the upper bound of expected income, myopia and time-discounting belong in (iii).

The most simple way to test (i)–(iii) would be head-to-head against other variables. We could construct variables that proxy for each channel, including interactions such as myopia x expected income growth or downside income risk x perceived mobility, then compare the R-squared attributed to each channel in a Shapley decomposition. We will probably find that beliefs matter much more.

So far, we find statistically significant but quantitatively small evidence that redistribution functions as insurance for longer-term risks which young people are more exposed to such as income/career uncertainty, housing, climate, and AI; weak evidence that redistribution functions as relief from present financial stress, which may be higher among young people; weak evidence that young people, who are often poorer earlier in their careers, favor redistribution due to myopia or time-discounting; and weak evidence that young people support redistribution because of misperceived future income needs or lack of experience with taxation.

[To do: Reference theory/empirics from the literature for each of the hypotheses above.]

[Nic: Values/personality traits such as generosity, materialism, and universalism/individualism could plausibly change over the life cycle, but we find them to weakly predict preferences for redistribution.]

2.3.2 Mechanism clusters and sample coverage

Table 2 defines the variable clusters used in the analysis that follows. Table A.1, reported in the appendix, records how many questions each survey fields within each cluster (our own, longitudinal, and recently-published data).

Table 2: What each candidate cluster measures

Cluster	Description
demographics	
age	Age in years
citizenship	Respondent and parents' birthplace and immigrant status
gender	Gender
marital status	Married cohabiting or single
race	Race and ethnicity
position	
ai/tech risk	Exposure to job loss from AI and whether technology helps
education	Highest level of education completed
employment	Employment status and hours
family income / background	Income, education and occupation of the respondent's parents and grandparents
financial stress/risk	Savings buffer income stability and financial satisfaction
health insurance	Insurance coverage and the risk of losing it
homeownership	Owning versus renting now and in childhood
income	Household income now expected and needed to live comfortably
location density	Urban suburban or rural residence
social class	Subjective social class and the respondent's own occupation and standing
unemployment risk	Job security and expected ease of re-employment
beliefs	
aggregate incentives / inequality positive-sum	Whether large pay gaps are needed to motivate effort and grow the pie
class conflict	Perceived conflict between rich and poor
deservingness of poor	Whether poverty reflects lack of effort or circumstance
discrimination	Whether minorities are seen as disadvantaged by discrimination and blocked opportunity, or by ability and effort
equality/dei zero-sum	Whether gains for women and minorities come at others' expense
experienced mobility	Whether the respondent's own effort and schooling have paid off, and how they compare with their parents
factual knowledge / misperceptions	Accuracy about verifiable economic facts: tax rates, who pays them, and how much the top 1 percent gained
government integrity / capability	Whether government is trustworthy, run for everyone, and able to reduce unequal opportunity
immigration	Perceived effect of immigrants and what makes someone truly American
individual incentives	Whether extra pay induces effort skill and schooling
individual incentives / tax elasticity	Whether higher taxes would make high earners and the middle class work less
inequality perception	Perceived change in the top 1 percent income share
other zero-sum	Zero-sum thinking about international trade
perceived mobility / opportunity	Perceived chance a poor child rises and whether mobility is falling
policy incidence	Who is believed to gain or lose when high earners are taxed
social trust	Whether most people can be trusted or would take advantage
wealth from advantages	Whether getting ahead requires connections family and luck
wealth from effort/merit	Whether hard work rather than luck explains who succeeds
wealth zero-sum	Whether the rich gain at others' expense rather than creating value
worldview/values	
climate/environment concern	Climate risk exposure and environmental engagement
distributive principle / desert	What pay ought to depend on and whether own pay is just

Cluster	Description
generosity / universalism	How much is given to others and how wide the circle of concern is, from close ties to strangers
materialism / ideal lifestyle	What the respondent values in a job and in life
patience	Time preference over money and long-term goals
religiosity	Importance of religion and frequency of attendance
redistributive preferences	
policy helping poor	Support for spending, services and guarantees aimed at low-income Americans
policy redistributive	Whether government should reduce income differences – the paper's main outcomes
policy tax	Preferred tax rates and whether current taxes are fair
other preferences	
fairness of the current distribution	Whether the existing distribution and economic system are fair or a serious problem
government scope	How much government should do overall, beyond redistribution specifically
immigration policy	Whether immigration should be increased or restricted
preferential hiring	Support for preferential hiring of women or minorities
stated reasons for own view change	Respondent's own account of why their redistribution views shifted
tax incidence / trickle-down	Who is claimed to gain when taxes on high earners are cut

We will find that although we consider a diverse range of beliefs, viewpoints, values, demographics and personal situations, a very small subset of variables—beliefs about the economic game—predict preferences for redistribution and explain the age gradient. No existing survey covers every major belief cluster (including our own, although it is broader than most).
[Nic: A Prolific wave 2 opportunity: disentangling related-but-distinct beliefs: What are the primitive beliefs driving things? Is it economic zero-sum, social zero-sum, causal attribution/deservingness, opportunity, or incentive effects? Which of these are distinct/orthogonal belief clusters? When we distinguish between them, which emerges as most important?]

2.3.3 Shapley decomposition: most-important predictors of preferences

[To do: Insert classes of variables collected/used in the longitudinal surveys. Chose candidate correlates representing every hypothesis I could think of from the literature.]

A Shapley decomposition splits a regression's R-squared across predictors. To handle correlated predictors fairly, the method averages each predictor's marginal contribution over all possible orderings of entry. Shares are non-negative and sum to the full model's R-squared, so each number is interpreted as that variable's percentage of explained variance. In the "by cluster" , we simply sum the percentage explained by each variable in the cluster.

In the below, Shapley decompositions for a range of surveys suggest that beliefs about the zero-sumness of wealth and social/racial equality are the most important predictors of redistributive preferences, followed by beliefs about deservingness/attribution, aggregate efficiency, and opportunity/mobility.

Our online survey suggests the importance of beliefs relating to aggregate efficiency, the zero-sumness of wealth, and the zero-sumness of DEI initiatives.

Shapley R^2 decomposition

Federal income tax should be more progressive (Own survey, 2025)

Full model $R^2 = 0.481$, $N = 2{,}415$ *(complete-case)*

By variable

#	Variable	% R^2
1	higher taxes on high incomes make people work less	19.6%
2	CEO pay gains came at expense of average workers	15.7%
3	people get rich at others' expense, not by creating value	15.7%
4	DEI creates opportunity for some at others' expense	12.5%
5	large income gap needed to motivate entrepreneurs	7.5%
6	harder or easier to move up now vs. parents' day	3.7%
7	chance a hard-working poor child reaches richest 20%	3.4%
	— variables with <3% contribution omitted —	

Figure 4: Shapley decomposition of preferences for tax progressivity, own 2025 survey, by variable.

By cluster

#	Cluster	% R^2
1	wealth zero-sum	31.4%
2	individual incentives / tax elasticity	19.7%
3	equality/dei zero-sum	12.9%
4	perceived mobility / opportunity	10.4%
5	aggregate incentives / inequality positive-sum	7.6%
	— clusters with <5% contribution omitted —	

Figure 5: Shapley decomposition of preferences for tax progressivity, own 2025 survey, by variable cluster.

Shapley R^2 decomposition

Govt should concern itself with income differences (Own survey, 2025)

Full model $R^2 = 0.371$, $N = 2{,}415$ *(complete-case)*

By variable

#	Variable	% R^2
1	people get rich at others' expense, not by creating value	16.6%
2	DEI creates opportunity for some at others' expense	13.9%
3	CEO pay gains came at expense of average workers	12.1%
4	higher taxes on high incomes make people work less	9.1%
5	large income gap needed to motivate entrepreneurs	6.2%
6	perceived risk of relocating due to climate events (10yr)	4.0%
7	harder or easier to move up now vs. parents' day	3.7%
8	age in years	3.6%
	— variables with <3% contribution omitted —	

Figure 6: Shapley decomposition of "government should reduce income differences," own 2025 survey, by variable.

By cluster

#	Cluster	% R^2
1	wealth zero-sum	30.1%
2	equality/dei zero-sum	14.4%
3	individual incentives / tax elasticity	9.2%
4	perceived mobility / opportunity	9.0%
5	aggregate incentives / inequality positive-sum	6.2%
	— clusters with <5% contribution omitted —	

Figure 7: Shapley decomposition of "government should reduce income differences," own 2025 survey, by cluster.

Data from Chinoy et al. (2026) suggests the importance of discrimination, zero-sum ethnicity, zero-sum wealth, and to a lesser extent, mobility/opportunity.

Shapley R^2 decomposition

Govt should reduce income differences (Chinoy et al., 2020-23)

Full model $R^2 = 0.391$, $N = 20{,}336$ *(pairwise-complete correlations)*

By variable

#	Variable	% R^2
1	generations of slavery make it hard for Blacks to leave lower class	16.5%
2	how serious a problem racism in the US is	14.1%
3	zero-sum between income classes	10.5%
4	how often women experience gender discrimination	9.6%
5	success in life is determined by forces outside our control	7.9%
6	zero-sum between ethnic groups	7.5%
7	incentivized guess: how much of the top 1% income rise came at the expense of the bottom 50%	5.0%
8	how often govt can be trusted to do what is right	5.0%
9	everybody in the US has a chance to make it	4.6%
	— variables with <3% contribution omitted —	

Figure 8: Shapley decomposition of support for redistribution, Chinoy et al., by variable.

By cluster

#	Cluster	% R^2
1	discrimination	40.2%
2	perceived mobility / opportunity	13.4%
3	wealth zero-sum	11.0%
4	equality/dei zero-sum	8.5%
5	factual knowledge / misperceptions	5.0%
6	government integrity / capability	5.0%
	— clusters with <5% contribution omitted —	

Figure 9: Shapley decomposition of support for redistribution, Chinoy et al., by cluster.

While Stantcheva (2021) originally found that views about government matter more than efficiency concerns, a different picture emerges once we remove questions about what the government *should* do (a subjective matter of where to draw the line between beliefs and preferences): aggregate efficiency, policy incidence, and attribution/deservingness appear most important, though the model's R-squared is low.

Shapley R^2 decomposition

Govt should be responsible for reducing income differences (Stantcheva, 2019)

Full model $R^2 = 0.174$, $N = 2{,}713$ *(complete-case)*

By variable

#	Variable	% R^2
1	raising income tax on high earners would hurt/help the economy	26.1%
2	why a person is rich: effort vs. advantages	14.4%
3	middle class mostly wins if overall taxes are increased	6.7%
4	working class mostly wins if overall taxes are increased	6.2%
5	upper-middle class mostly wins if overall taxes are increased	6.0%
6	age in years	5.0%
7	Laffer effect: tax cuts on high-income households and the deficit	4.5%
8	lower class or poor mostly wins if taxes on high earners are cut	4.1%
9	upper class mostly wins if overall taxes are increased	3.2%
10	perceived share of national income going to top 1%	3.1%
	— variables with <3% contribution omitted —	

Figure 10: Shapley decomposition of support for redistribution, Stantcheva, by variable.

By cluster

#	Cluster	% R^2
1	policy incidence	32.2%
2	aggregate incentives / inequality positive-sum	31.7%
3	wealth from effort/merit	14.4%
4	age	5.0%
	— clusters with <5% contribution omitted —	

Figure 11: Shapley decomposition of support for redistribution, Stantcheva, by cluster.

ANES features few questions about relevant economic beliefs, and WVS has good questions but poor coverage for the same respondents in the same year, so GSS has the least-deficient longitudinal data for a Shapley decomposition. In the GSS data, zero-sum wealth, perceived class conflict, and attribution/deservingness are the most-predictive clusters.

Shapley R^2 decomposition

Govt should reduce income differentials (GSS)

Full model $R^2 = 0.322$, $N = 2{,}335$ *(pairwise-complete correlations)*

By variable

#	Variable	% R^2
1	inequality exists for benefit of rich	20.4%
2	conflict between poor and rich in usa?	8.5%
3	inequality due to lack of solidarity	7.3%
4	r's pay is just	4.5%
5	rich buy better health care than poor	4.2%
6	r earns what they deserve	3.4%
7	family income in constant dollars (REALINC, 1986 base)	3.3%
8	rich buy better education than poor	3.3%
	— variables with <3% contribution omitted —	

Figure 12: Shapley decomposition of "government should reduce income differences," GSS, by variable.

By cluster

#	Cluster	% R^2
1	wealth zero-sum	23.1%
2	class conflict	15.7%
3	wealth from advantages	12.5%
4	distributive principle / desert	9.5%
5	income	7.4%
	— clusters with <5% contribution omitted —	

Figure 13: Shapley decomposition of "government should reduce income differences," GSS, by cluster.

2.4 Explaining the Age Gradient

2.4.1 Age gradients in beliefs: suggestive figures

Our online survey and Chinoy et al. (2026) find strong age gradients in zero-sum wealth beliefs: young people on average are more likely to believe that people become wealthy by taking from others.

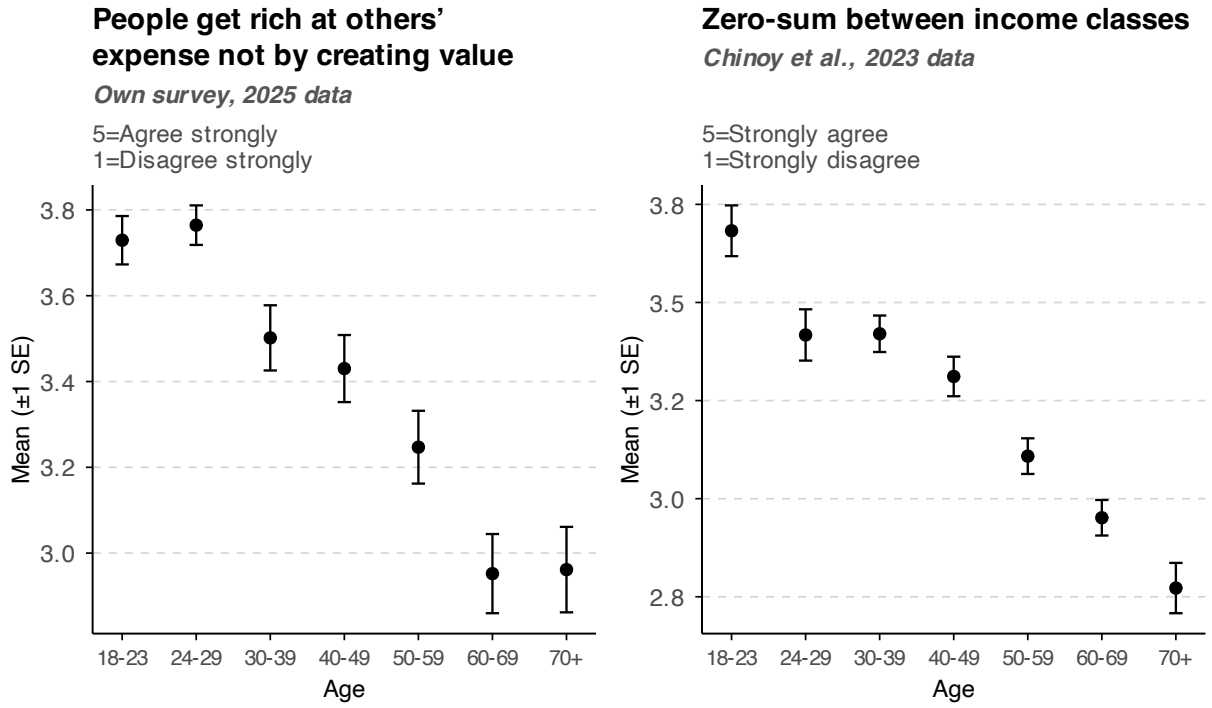


Figure 14: Age gradients in zero-sum wealth beliefs: own 2025 survey and Chinoy et al.

The WVS also displays prominent age gradients in a question gauging beliefs about mobility and attribution of success. We will find this theme (deservingness/opportunity) to be important in the Gelbach decomposition for the GSS.

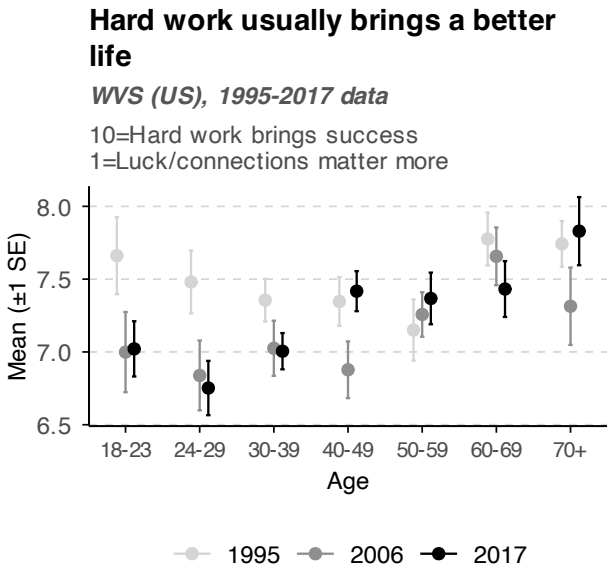


Figure 15: Age gradient in beliefs about whether hard work brings success (WVS), by wave.

While our online survey finds that young people see DEI as less zero-sum, Chinoy et al. (2026) finds that they see ethnic-group gains as *more* zero-sum: young people are more likely to agree that "if one ethnic group becomes richer, this generally comes at the expense of other groups in the country." This latter result may reflect framing: "richer" implies the majority group, priming respondents to think about rich whites getting richer rather than poor non-whites getting richer.

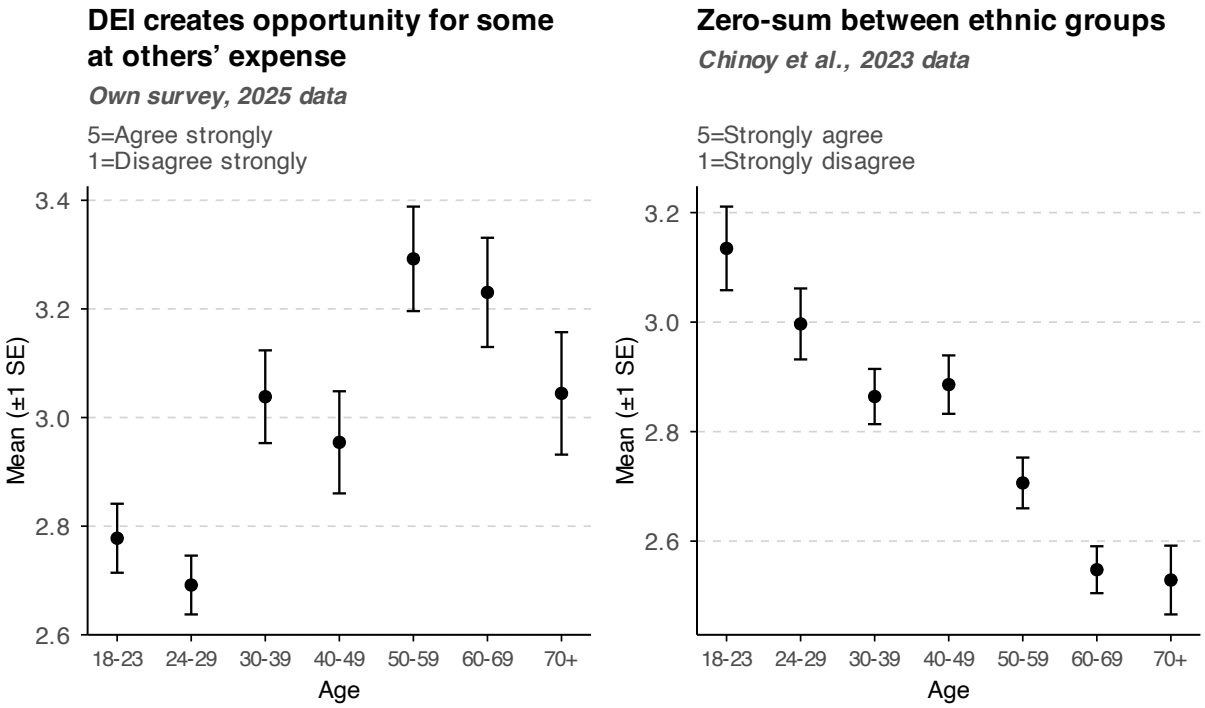


Figure 16: Age gradients in social and DEI zero-sum beliefs: own survey and Chinoy et al.

Backing up the point that framing could be the issue, young people are less likely to think that non-citizens' income is zero-sum and more likely to think racism is a problem (admittedly, not the exact same question, but related).

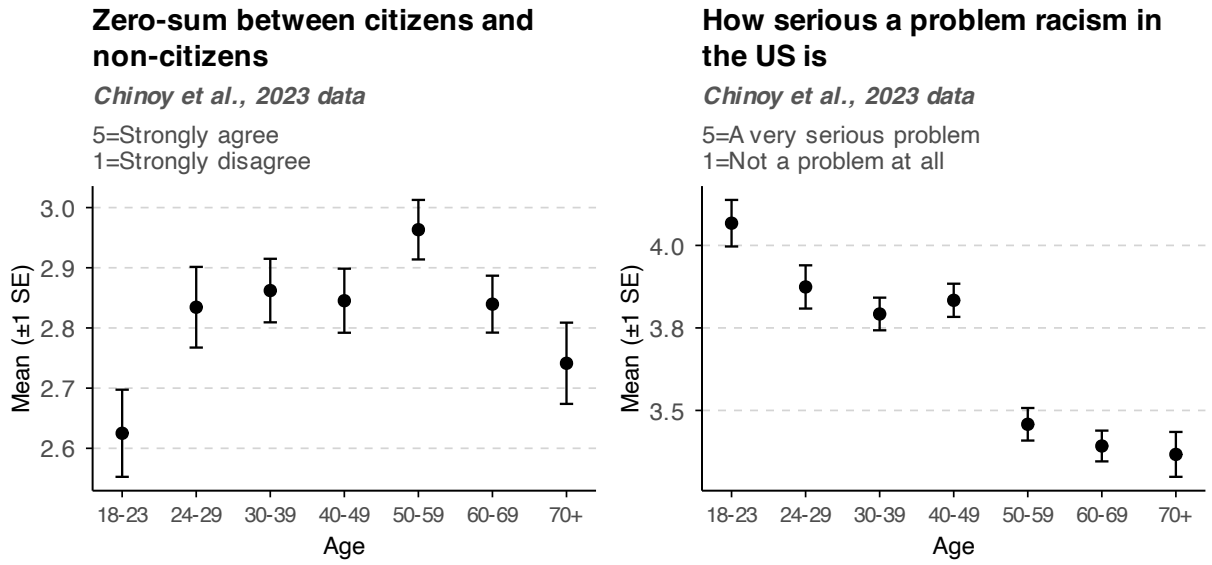


Figure 17: Framing check: age gradients in zero-sum beliefs about non-citizens and in views of racism (Chinoy et al.).

Our only long-running zero-sum wealth question, from the WVS, is inconclusive about whether the gradient has widened over time. However, the GSS shows that young people are much more likely nowadays to believe that rich people benefit from structural advantages.

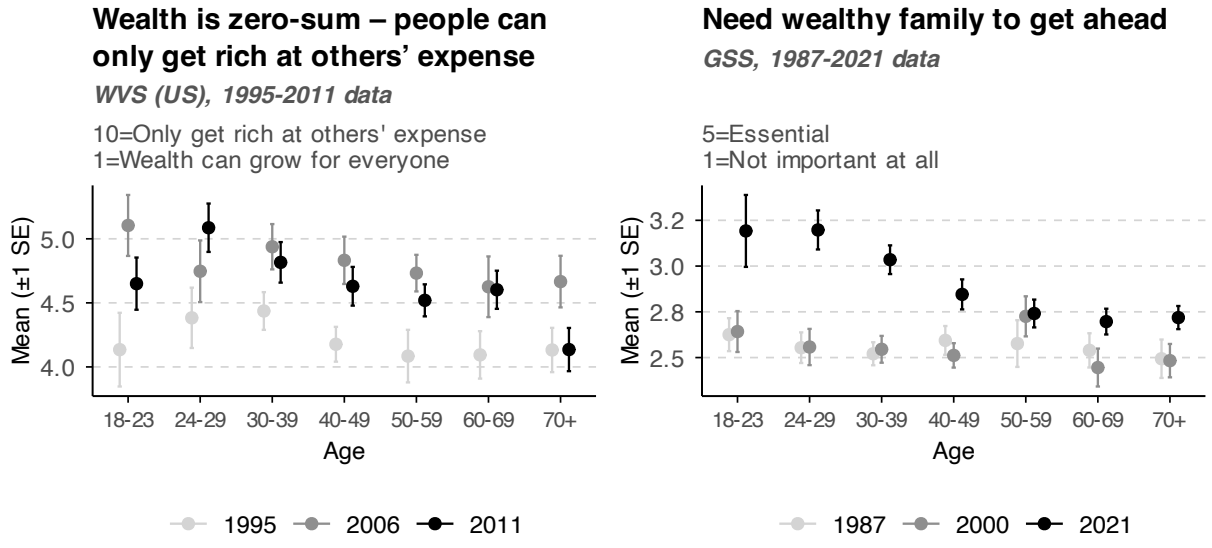


Figure 18: Long-run evolution of zero-sum wealth beliefs (WVS) and structural-advantage beliefs (GSS), by wave.

Though there is no long-running zero-sum race/social equality question, the ANES suggests that the age gradient in support for affirmative action is widening. The rise in the share of non-whites in younger cohorts could be part of the explanation.

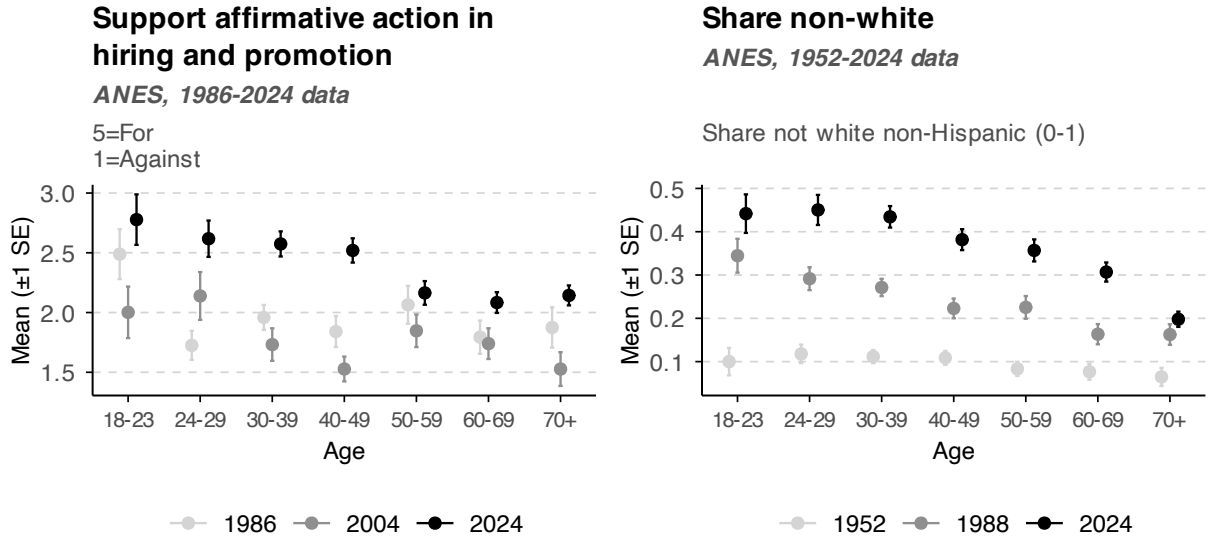


Figure 19: Long-run evolution of the age gradient in affirmative-action support and the non-white share of cohorts (ANES).

There also seems to be an evolving gradient in perceived economic situation: younger people nowadays are less likely to feel that their financial situation has improved or that they are in a high income class.

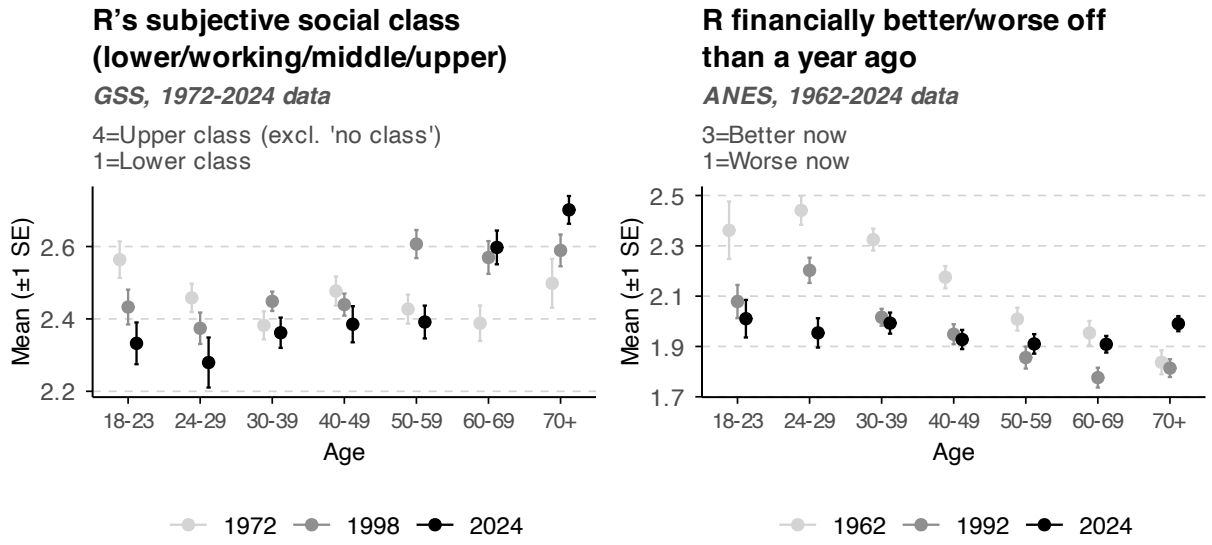


Figure 20: Age gradients in perceived economic position: subjective social class (GSS) and change in personal finances (ANES).

Further, young Americans tend to display more post-materialist values (willing to trade off economic growth for other social goals), although it is unclear whether this gradient has evolved or always existed.

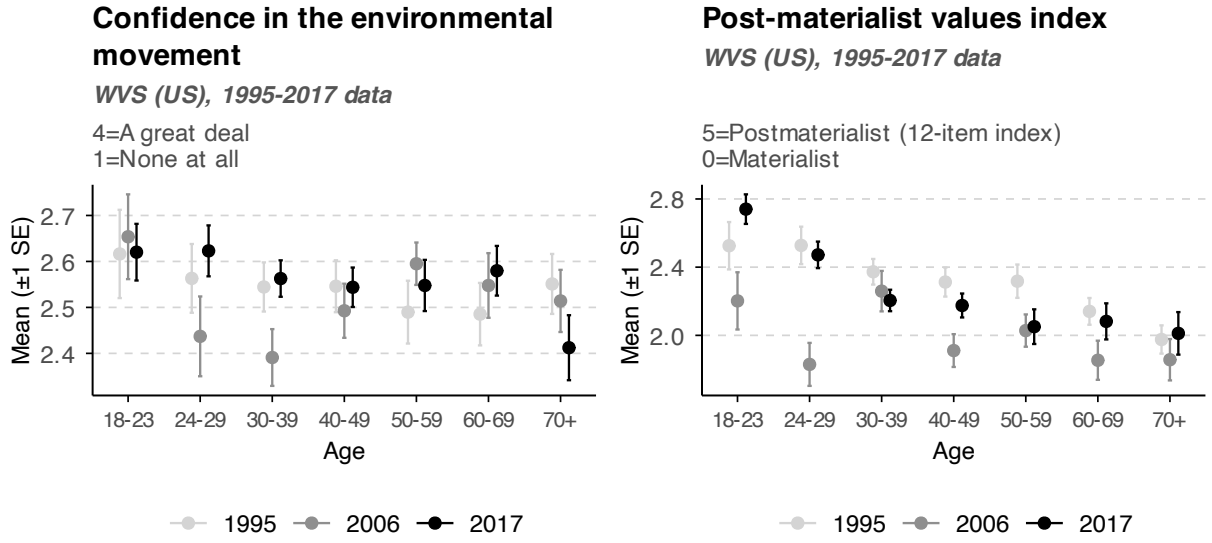


Figure 21: Age gradients in post-materialist values and confidence in the environmental movement (WVS).

Lastly, young Americans seem increasingly less confident in the U.S. government.

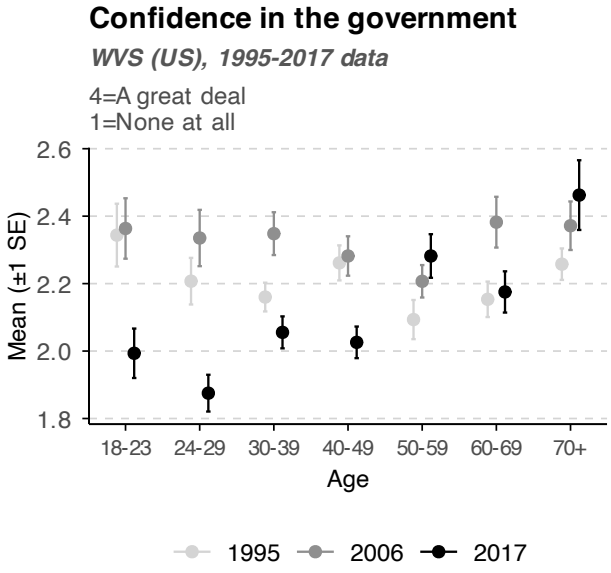


Figure 22: Age gradient in confidence in the U.S. government (WVS), by wave.

2.4.2 Gelbach decomposition

Methodology: Our Gelbach decomposition compares a "short" model with only age as a covariate to a "full" model with age and many other variables (in this case, beliefs) as covariates. Our full model will feature a smaller coefficient (in absolute value) on the age covariate, suggesting an omitted variable bias in the short model that will be attributed to different belief covariates. If a belief is negatively correlated with age and positively correlated with demand for redistribution (or vice-versa), it will be an important/highly-ranked contributor in the Gelbach decomposition. If it is correlated with age but not preferences, or preferences but not age, it will not show up in the decomposition.

As we would expect, zerosumrich is highly-ranked because it is negatively correlated with age and positively correlated with preferences. However, taxdemotivates and gapmotivates are unimportant in the decomposition (i.e., do not explain the age gradient) because, while they are highly correlated with preferences, they are not correlated with age. For the progressivity outcome, beliefs about zero-sum wealth and zero-sum DEI combine to explain the majority of the age gradient.

Gelbach decomposition of age gradient

Govt. should concern itself with income differences (Own survey, 2025)

37.0% explained, $\beta_{short} = -0.209$, $\beta_{full} = -0.132$, $N = 2{,}403$

tier 1 candidate variables: beliefs

#	Item	Contribution	% of explained
1	people get rich at others' expense, not by creating value	-0.043	55.3%
2	DEI creates opportunity for some at others' expense	-0.021	27.4%
3	r's education will pay off economically	-0.007	9.6%
4	CEO pay gains came at expense of average workers	-0.007	8.5%
5	harder or easier to move up now vs. parents' day	-0.005	6.0%
6	r's future hard work will pay off	0.004	-5.6%
7	higher taxes on high incomes make people work less	0.004	-5.3%
	— 17 items with <5% contribution omitted —		

Figure 23: Gelbach decomposition of the young–old gap in "government should reduce income differences," own 2025 survey.

Gelbach decomposition of age gradient

Federal income tax should be more progressive (Own survey, 2025)

75.5% explained, $\beta_{short} = -0.112$, $\beta_{full} = -0.028$, $N = 2{,}403$

tier 1 candidate variables: beliefs

#	Item	Contribution	% of explained
1	people get rich at others' expense, not by creating value	-0.045	52.8%
2	DEI creates opportunity for some at others' expense	-0.020	24.2%
3	higher taxes on high incomes make people work less	0.009	-10.8%
4	CEO pay gains came at expense of average workers	-0.009	10.5%
5	r's past hard work has paid off	-0.005	6.1%
6	harder or easier to move up now vs. parents' day	-0.005	5.6%
	— 18 items with <5% contribution omitted —		

Figure 24: Gelbach decomposition of the young–old gap in tax progressivity, own 2025 survey.

Cross-checking with outside surveys, data from Chinoy et al. (2026) yields similar findings: beliefs about zero-sum wealth, race/discrimination, and opportunity combine to explain a large portion of the gradient.

Gelbach decomposition of age gradient

Govt. should reduce income differences (Chinoy et al., 2020-23)

80.9% explained, $\beta_{short} = -0.186$, $\beta_{full} = -0.036$, $N = 19{,}953$

tier 1 candidate variables: beliefs, government

#	Item	Contribution	% of explained
1	zero-sum between income classes	-0.033	21.8%
2	how serious a problem racism in the US is	-0.029	19.0%
3	success in life is determined by forces outside our control	-0.027	17.6%
4	zero-sum between ethnic groups	-0.020	13.3%
5	how often women experience gender discrimination	-0.019	12.3%
6	how often govt can be trusted to do what is right	-0.008	5.2%
	— 12 items with <5% contribution omitted —		

Figure 25: Gelbach decomposition of the young–old gap in support for redistribution, Chinoy et al.

The GSS decomposition follows similar themes, but features a slightly different set of beliefs: structural advantages of the rich and conflict between the rich and poor.

Gelbach decomposition of age gradient

Govt. should reduce income differentials (GSS, 2000)

67.4% explained, $\beta_{short} = -0.064$, $\beta_{full} = -0.021$, $N = 770$

tier 1 candidate variables: beliefs

#	Item	Contribution	% of explained
1	inequality exists for benefit of rich	-0.025	57.2%
2	inequality due to lack of solidarity	-0.005	12.5%
3	r earns what they deserve	-0.005	11.5%
4	must be corrupt to get to top in america	-0.005	10.4%
5	rich buy better education than poor	-0.004	8.8%
6	effort rewarded in america	-0.003	7.8%
7	pay differences -> american prosperity	0.003	-7.7%
	— 7 items with <5% contribution omitted —		

Figure 26: Gelbach decomposition of the young–old gap in support for redistribution, GSS.

2.5 Robustness: Evidence from Other Recent Surveys

Cross-checking against the most recent waves of the GSS and ANES, together with the large survey of Chinoy et al. (2026), confirms the finding.

Table 3: Single-period bivariate OLS regressions

	GSS reduce inc. diffs.	ANES guaranteed income	Chinoy et al. reduce inc. diffs.
Age	-0.2573***	-0.2064***	-0.1811***
	(0.0238)	(0.0148)	(0.0061)
N	1,710	4,520	26,730

Data: GSS fielded 2021, ANES fielded 2024, Chinoy et al. fielded 2020-23
Both age and outcome z-scored (per-SD units). All outcomes coded high = pro-redistribution. Standard errors in parentheses.
* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

3 The Widening Age Gradient in Support for Redistribution: Evidence and Determinants

The cross-sectional age gradient documented in Section 2 is not a recent development: it has been present for decades and has grown more pronounced over time. This section turns to that dynamic. We first describe the repeated cross-sectional surveys—the GSS and the ANES—that make it possible to trace the gradient over half a century, and then present our two main results: that the age gap in support for redistribution has widened substantially over time, and that this widening reflects cohort rather than pure age or period effects. Our main focus is on these last two questions; some additional descriptive findings from the repeated cross-sections are summarized in the appendix.

3.1 GSS and ANES Survey: Repeated Cross-Sections

Unlike our own 2025 survey, which offers a single, richly detailed cross-section, the General Social Survey (GSS) and the American National Election Study (ANES) have fielded closely comparable redistribution questions repeatedly since the 1970s. It is this repetition that lets us ask not only whether an age gradient exists today but how it has *evolved*: with many waves spanning several decades, we observe the same age brackets at different points in time, which allows us to begin separating the effects of age, birth cohort, and survey period. The trade-off is coverage of mechanisms—these surveys ask far fewer belief questions than ours—so we use them chiefly for the time dimension and rely on the 2025 survey for the underlying determinants. As Figure 2 already suggests, the gradient is barely noticeable in the 1970s and 1980s but pronounced in the most recent waves.

3.2 The Time Evolution of the Gap

The widening of the generational divide over time is strongly statistically significant. The negative age coefficient suggests that older Americans support redistribution less, the positive period coefficient suggests that support across the population has increased over time, and the negative coefficient on the age-period interaction suggests that in later (more recent) years, the age gradient has steepened.

Table 4: Multi-period OLS regressions with age-period interaction

	GSS reduce inc. diffs.	ANES guaranteed income
Age	-0.0356**	-0.0239***
	(0.0153)	(0.0091)
Period	0.0365***	0.0428***
	(0.0079)	(0.0027)
Age × Period	-0.0506***	-0.0278***
	(0.0078)	(0.0027)
N	13,071	45,853

Data: GSS waves 1987-2021, ANES waves 1972-2024
Both age and outcome z-scored (per-SD units). All outcomes coded high = pro-redistribution. Period = decades since first wave used, kept continuous. Standard errors in parentheses.
* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.
F-test of Age × Period = 0: GSS $F = 42.17$, ANES $F = 106.86$.

What might explain this widening? We consider two broad classes of hypotheses.

(i) **The evolving economic environment: inequality, growth, and social mobility.** Successive cohorts have come of age under different macroeconomic conditions—rising income and wealth inequality, slower and more volatile growth, and declining intergenerational mobility. If the young today face materially worse prospects than the young of earlier decades did, they may form more zero-sum and more pro-redistribution beliefs than their predecessors held at the same age, steepening the gradient over time.

(ii) **Demographic change: the rising non-white share of younger cohorts.** The share of non-white individuals has grown fastest among the youngest age groups. Because attitudes toward redistribution and zero-sum thinking differ systematically across groups, this compositional shift in the youngest brackets could steepen the measured age gradient even absent any change in beliefs within groups.

3.3 Disentangling the Role of Age, Period, and Cohort

The age, period, and cohort (APC) effects cannot be separately identified without additional restrictions. A *widening* of the gradient, however, cannot come from period effects alone; it must reflect cohort effects or time-varying age effects. The figures below offer suggestive evidence. Generations start at different mean levels—partly explained by the positive period effects in Table 4, but potentially also reflecting positive cohort effects. Preferences are fairly stable over time within a generation, suggesting cohort effects, while a mild decline over the life cycle suggests some age effects as well (especially if period effects trend in the opposite direction). Later sections test whether the underlying mechanisms are more consistent with the age/life-cycle hypothesis or the cohort/imprinting hypothesis.

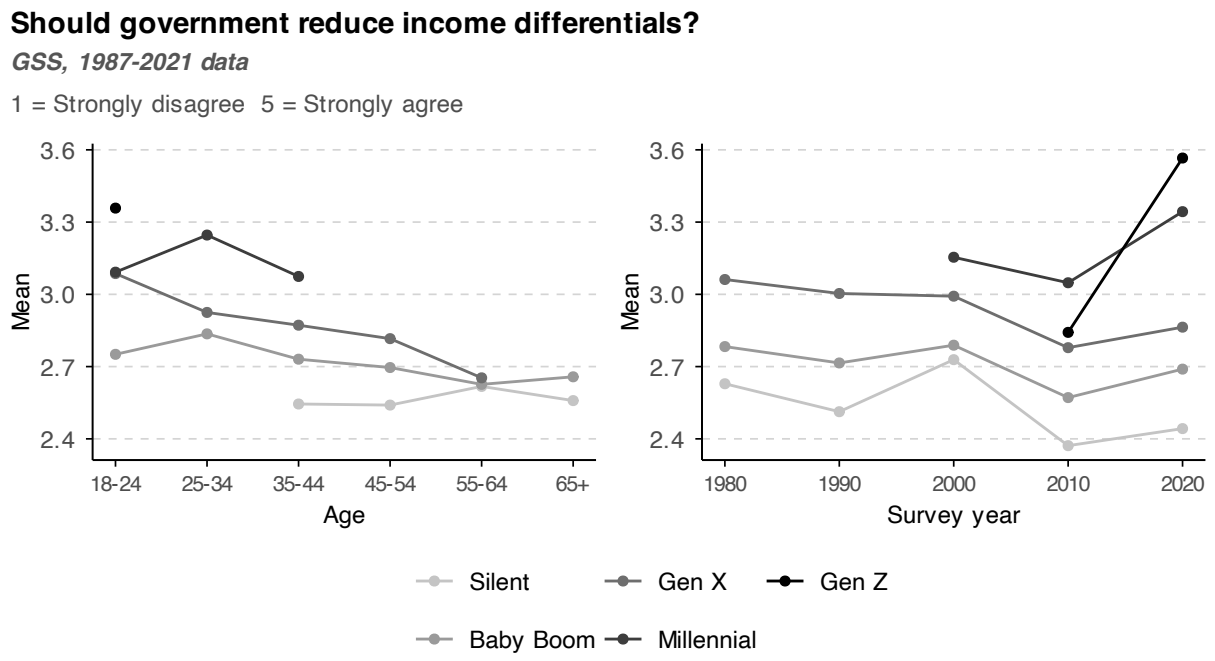


Figure 27: GSS (GOVEQINC): mean support by age bracket (left) and by survey year (right), plotted separately for each birth generation. Generations begin at different levels and are fairly flat over the life cycle, pointing to a cohort component in the gradient.

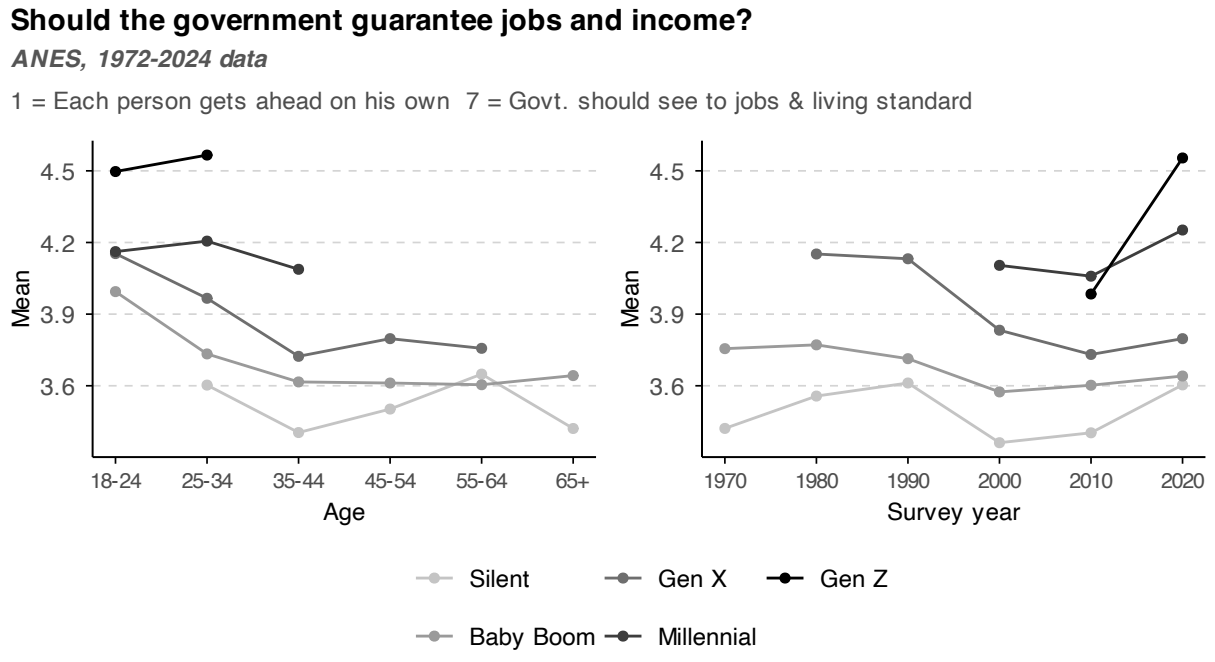
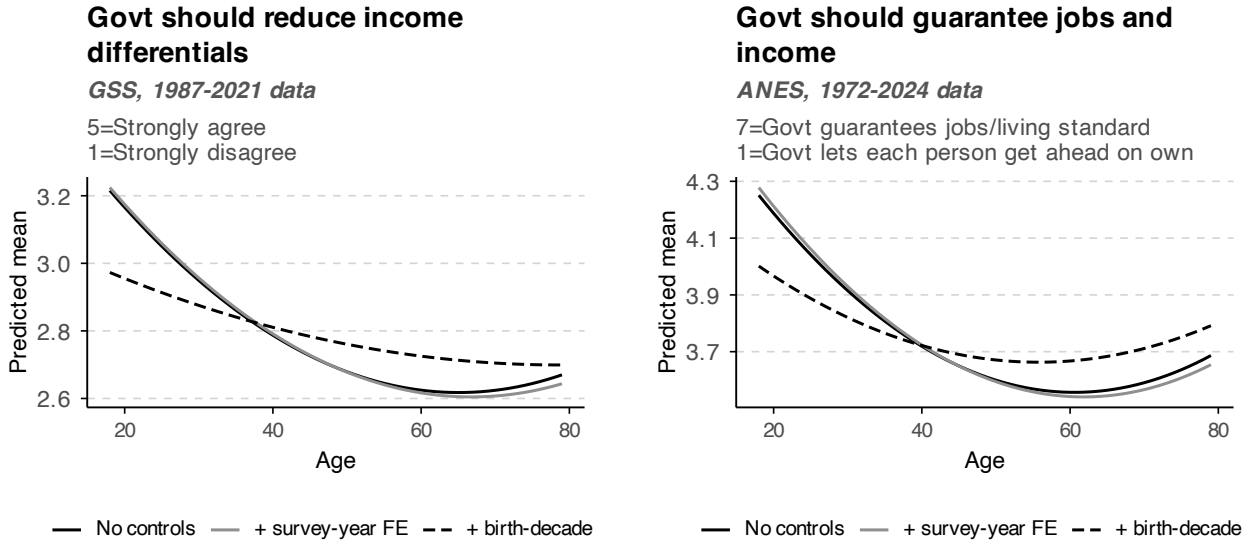


Figure 28: ANES (VCF0809): mean support by age bracket (left) and by survey year (right), plotted separately for each birth generation.

Plotting age against predicted mean preferences under birth-decade (cohort) versus survey-year (period) fixed effects suggests that cohort effects drive a large part of the age gradient, whereas period effects—as expected—do not: controlling for birth-decade fixed effects shrinks the age slope, while controlling for survey-year fixed effects leaves it essentially unchanged (Figure 29).



(a) GSS (GOVEQINC)

(b) ANES (VCF0809)

Figure 29: The age–preference slope under birth-decade (cohort) versus survey-year (period) fixed effects. Controlling for cohort flattens the age slope, whereas controlling for period leaves it essentially unchanged—consistent with cohort effects, rather than period effects, driving much of the age gradient.

3.4 Why did beliefs change?

[To do: Can look into growth during formative years, inequality, and exposure to diverse groups. Emphasize zero-sum wealth/income vs. zero-sum race/social equality, since a shock may move them in opposite directions (not explored in Chinoy et al. (2026)).]

4 Conclusion

Young Americans support redistribution far more than their elders, and we have asked why. Testing a broad menu of explanations within a single, purpose-built survey, we find that the age gap is overwhelmingly a matter of *beliefs* rather than circumstances: differences in zero-sum thinking about wealth, together with the belief that progressive taxation dulls incentives, account for the bulk of it, while income, financial position, exposure to risk, life-cycle considerations, and demographics play little role. Because zero-sum beliefs are both strongly related to redistributive preferences and sharply patterned by age, they alone explain the majority of the young–old divide. These conclusions hold up across independent cross-sectional and longitudinal surveys.

The gap is also growing. Repeated cross-sections reaching back to the 1970s show an age gradient that has steepened markedly, and the widening in zero-sum beliefs accounts for a sizable part of the trend. Why the age distribution of these beliefs has shifted—whether through the formative economic experiences of recent cohorts, rising inequality, changing exposure to diverse groups, or other channels—is a question our data can only begin to answer, and one we see as central to understanding the future politics of redistribution. [To do: Add a forward-looking / policy-implications sentence once Section 3 is settled.]

A Survey Coverage

Table A.1: Survey coverage

Group	Cluster	GSS	ANES	WVS (US)	Own	Chinoy	Stant.	Alesina
demographics	age	1 (1972-2024)	1 (1952-2024)	1 (1995-2017)	1	1	1	1
	citizenship	1 (1977-2024)	–	3 (2006-2017)	2	1	–	2
	gender	1 (1972-2024)	1 (1948-2024)	1 (1995-2017)	3	1	1	1
	marital status	–	1 (1952-2024)	1 (1995-2017)	3	1	1	1
	race	–	1 (1948-2024)	1 (1995-2017)	5	1	1	–
position	ai/tech risk	–	–	3 (2006-2017)	1	–	–	–
	education	–	1 (1948-2024)	1 (1995-2017)	1	1	1	1
	employment	1 (1972-2024)	1 (1952-2024)	1 (1995-2017)	7	1	1	1
	family income / background	3 (1972-2024)	1 (1952-1996)	3 (2017)	5	6	–	3
	financial stress/risk	3 (1972-2024)	2 (1956-2024)	2 (1995-2017)	2	–	–	–
	health insurance	1 (1991-2004)	1 (1992-2024)	–	1	–	–	–
	homeownership	2 (1985-2024)	1 (1952-2024)	–	1	–	–	–
	income	3 (1972-2024)	4 (1948-2024)	1 (1995-2017)	5	3	1	1
	location density	3 (1972-2024)	1 (1952-2000)	2 (1995-2017)	2	1	–	–
	social class	3 (1972-2024)	3 (1952-2016)	1 (1995-2017)	1	–	1	1
	unemployment risk	3 (1973-2024)	5 (1984-2024)	1 (1995-1999)	2	–	–	–
beliefs	aggregate incentives / inequality positive-sum	3 (1987-2021)	–	1 (1995-2017)	1	–	3	–
	class conflict	2 (1987-2021)	–	–	–	–	–	–
	deservingness of poor	1 (2018)	–	1 (1999-2017)	–	–	–	1
	discrimination	11 (1990-2024)	2 (1986-2024)	–	–	3	–	–
	equality/dei zero-sum	1	1 (1984-2012)	–	2	2	–	–
	experienced mobility	3 (1989-2024)	–	–	3	1	–	2
	factual knowledge / misperceptions	–	–	–	–	1	5	–
	government integrity / capability	–	3 (1958-2024)	2 (1995-2017)	–	1	1	2
	immigration	4 (1996-2024)	1 (2004-2024)	2 (1995-2017)	–	1	–	–
	individual incentives	3 (1987-2000)	–	–	–	–	–	–
	individual incentives / tax elasticity	–	–	–	1	–	12	–
	inequality perception	–	2 (2004-2020)	–	–	–	2	–
	other zero-sum	–	–	–	–	1	–	–
	perceived mobility / opportunity	–	–	–	3	12	–	5
	policy incidence	1 (1987-2021)	–	–	–	–	10	–
	social trust	2 (1972-2024)	3 (1964-2020)	3 (1995-2017)	–	1	–	–
	wealth from advantages	11 (1987-2021)	–	–	–	–	–	–
	wealth from effort/merit	7 (1973-2024)	–	2 (1995-2017)	–	–	1	1
	wealth zero-sum	4 (1978-2024)	–	1 (1995-2011)	2	2	–	–
worldview/values	climate/environment concern	1 (2021)	2 (1984-2024)	4 (1995-2017)	1	–	–	–
	distributive principle / desert	8 (1990-2021)	–	–	–	–	1	–
	generosity / universalism	–	1 (1992-2024)	3 (1995-2017)	2	4	–	–
	materialism / ideal lifestyle	5 (1989-2024)	–	8 (1995-2017)	7	–	–	–
	patience	–	–	1 (1995-2017)	7	–	–	–
	religiosity	3 (1972-2024)	2 (1970-2024)	2 (1995-2017)	–	1	–	–

Group	Cluster	GSS	ANES	WVS (US)	Own	Chinoy	Stant.	Alesina
redistributive preferences	policy helping poor	3 (1975-2024)	8 (1956-2024)	2 (1995-2017)	3	2	5	–
	policy redistributive	2 (1978-2024)	–	1 (1995-2017)	1	1	3	–
	policy tax	3 (1987-2021)	–	–	4	2	5	5
other preferences	fairness of the current distribution	1 (1987-2021)	–	1 (2006-2017)	–	1	4	2
	government scope	1	2 (1984-2024)	–	–	1	2	2
	immigration policy	1 (1996-2014)	1 (1992-2024)	2 (1995-2017)	–	1	–	–
	preferential hiring	1 (1996-2024)	1 (1986-2024)	–	–	1	–	–
	stated reasons for own view change	–	–	–	9	–	–	–
	tax incidence / trickle-down	–	–	–	–	–	1	1

Question inventory for the Section 4.1 decomposition. Cells give the number of questions the survey *asks* in that cluster; – marks a cluster the survey does not measure at all. Above the rule are the 372 candidate items, of which 356 enter our battery; the rest are catalogued for coverage but stay out of the models. **Below the rule** are the 86 *preference* items – the outcomes themselves and normative *should government* questions – shown for coverage but excluded from the decomposition by construction, since they restate what we are trying to explain. Ideology and civic participation are omitted entirely. GSS counts are our 107-variable extract plus known relevant items from the full GSS (flagged in the catalog), which holds thousands more – a curated lower bound, not an exhaustive inventory. WVS is US respondents only. For GSS, ANES and WVS (US) the parenthetical is the span of years those questions were actually fielded, which varies widely within a survey; the cross-sections were each fielded once: Own survey, 2025; Chinoy et al., 2020-23; Stantcheva, 2019; Alesina et al., 2016. Cluster wording is ours.

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